Predicting YouTube Video Views Using Machine Learning: An End-to-End Regression Approach

Author: Koppuravuri Sri Hinduja (241FA18284)

Email: koppuravurisrihinduja@gmail.com

Institution: Department of Computer Science & Engineering

Date: November 2026

Repository: https://github.com/Srihinduja27/youtube-view-prediction

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Abstract

This project focuses on predicting YouTube video views using Machine Learning regression techniques. The project was developed using YouTube trending video data containing information related to video category, publishing time, title, description, tags, and trending behavior. The complete workflow included data preprocessing, exploratory data analysis, feature engineering, model development, model comparison, hyperparameter tuning, feature importance analysis, statistical P-value analysis, and prediction on unseen data. Multiple regression models including Linear Regression, Random Forest, Extra Trees, and XGBoost were trained and evaluated. Random Forest achieved the best baseline performance with an R^2 Score of 0.5706. Therefore, it was selected for hyperparameter tuning using RandomizedSearchCV. The Tuned Random Forest achieved an R^2 Score of 0.7414 on the transformed target scale and was selected as the final model. The project demonstrates a complete end-to-end Machine Learning workflow for predicting YouTube video popularity.

Keywords: YouTube, Machine Learning, Regression, Random Forest, View Prediction, Hyperparameter Tuning, Feature Engineering.

I. Introduction

YouTube is one of the largest video-sharing platforms where millions of videos receive different levels of audience engagement. The number of views received by a video is an important indicator of its popularity. However, predicting video views is challenging because popularity depends on multiple factors such as category, publishing time, title, description, tags, and trending behavior. Machine Learning techniques can analyze historical data and identify relationships between these factors and video views. In this project, regression algorithms were used to predict YouTube video views. The project follows an end-to-end approach starting from data preprocessing and ending with final model selection and unseen data prediction.

II. Problem Statement

The number of views received by a YouTube video varies significantly and depends on multiple factors. The relationship between video metadata and views is complex and may not be linear. Therefore, the problem addressed in this project is to develop a Machine Learning regression model that can predict YouTube video views using available video-related features.

III. Research Objectives

The main objective of this project is to develop a Machine Learning model for predicting YouTube video views. The project aims to preprocess the dataset, analyze data patterns, create useful features, train multiple regression models, compare their performance, perform hyperparameter tuning on the best model, analyze feature importance, perform statistical validation, and predict views for unseen data.

IV. Research Questions

This project investigates whether YouTube video metadata can be effectively used to predict video views. It also examines which Machine Learning regression model provides better predictive performance and whether hyperparameter tuning can improve the selected model.

V. Literature Review / Related Work

Machine Learning techniques are commonly used for predicting online content popularity and user engagement. Linear Regression is often used as a basic regression model, while ensemble algorithms such as Random Forest and Extra Trees are capable of learning nonlinear relationships from structured data. XGBoost is another popular algorithm used for prediction problems. Based on these approaches, this project compares multiple regression algorithms to identify a suitable model for predicting YouTube video views.

VI. Research Gap

Many prediction projects focus mainly on model training and accuracy evaluation. This project follows a more complete Machine Learning workflow by including data preprocessing, exploratory analysis, feature engineering, multiple model comparison, hyperparameter tuning, feature importance analysis, P-value analysis, and unseen data prediction.

VII. Dataset Description

The project uses a YouTube trending videos dataset containing information related to videos from multiple countries. The dataset includes features such as category ID, publication details, trending date, title, description, tags, comments status, ratings status, and video error information. The target variable selected for prediction is the number of video views. Since YouTube videos can have highly varying view counts, the target variable showed a highly skewed distribution. Therefore, appropriate preprocessing and transformation techniques were applied before model development.

VIII. Methodology

The project followed an end-to-end Machine Learning methodology. Initially, the dataset was cleaned and prepared for analysis. Exploratory Data Analysis was performed to understand the distribution of important variables and identify outliers. New features were created from publication dates, titles, descriptions, and tags. The processed dataset was divided into training and testing data. Multiple regression models were trained and evaluated using standard regression metrics. Random Forest was identified as the best baseline model and further optimized through hyperparameter tuning. Finally, feature importance analysis, P-value analysis, and unseen data prediction were performed.

IX. System / ML Workflow

Raw Dataset → Data Cleaning → Data Preprocessing → EDA → Outlier Analysis → Feature Engineering → Target Transformation → Train-Test Split → Model Training → Model Evaluation → Model Comparison → Hyperparameter Tuning → Final Model Selection → Feature Importance Analysis → P-Value Analysis → Unseen Data Prediction.

X. Data Preprocessing

Data preprocessing was performed to make the dataset suitable for Machine Learning. Missing and inconsistent values were examined, and date-related columns were converted into appropriate datetime formats. A new feature called **`days_to_trending`** was created by calculating the difference between the publication date and trending date. The feature was validated, resulting in zero missing values and zero negative values. The target variable, views, had a highly skewed distribution. Therefore, logarithmic transformation was applied to reduce skewness and improve model learning.

XI. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA)

Exploratory Data Analysis was performed to understand the dataset and identify important patterns. Variables such as views, likes, dislikes, and comment count were analyzed. The analysis revealed the presence of significant outliers. These outliers were not simply removed because extremely high engagement values can represent genuinely popular or viral YouTube videos. Removing them could result in the loss of meaningful real-world information. The distribution of views was highly skewed, which supported the use of logarithmic transformation for the target variable.

XII. Feature Engineering / Feature Selection

Several new features were engineered from the available data. Date-related features were extracted from publication information. Text-related features such as title length, title word count, description length, description word count, and tag count were created. The `days_to_trending` feature was also included to represent the time taken by a video to appear in trending data. After training the final model, feature importance analysis was performed. The preprocessing pipeline generated a total of 19 processed features, and feature importance values were extracted from the final Random Forest model.

XIII. Model Development

Four regression models were developed and evaluated in this project:

- Linear Regression
- Random Forest Regressor
- Extra Trees Regressor
- XGBoost Regressor

Linear Regression was used as a basic baseline model. Ensemble-based algorithms were used because they can capture complex nonlinear relationships between the input features and the target variable. All models were trained using the processed dataset and evaluated using the same regression metrics.

XIV. Experimental Setup

The dataset was divided into training and testing datasets. The target variable was transformed using logarithmic transformation due to its highly skewed distribution. A preprocessing pipeline was used to ensure consistent feature transformation. Models were trained using the training data and evaluated on the test data. The experiments used Mean Absolute Error, Root Mean Squared Error, and R^2 Score for model evaluation. RandomizedSearchCV was used for hyperparameter optimization of the best-performing model.

XV. Model Validation

The trained models were validated using test data that was not used during training. This approach helped evaluate the ability of the models to generalize to new data. The performance of each model was measured using MAE, RMSE, and R^2 Score. The R^2 Score was mainly used to compare the predictive capability of the regression models.

XVI. Hyperparameter Tuning

Random Forest achieved the best performance among the baseline models. Therefore, it was selected for hyperparameter tuning. RandomizedSearchCV was used instead of GridSearchCV because it efficiently searches different parameter combinations while reducing computational cost. The tuning process tested 10 parameter combinations using 3-fold cross-validation, resulting in a total of 30 model fits.

The best parameters obtained were:

- `n_estimators`: 200
- `min_samples_split`: 5
- `min_samples_leaf`: 1
- `max_features`: `log2`
- `max_depth`: 30

The best cross-validation R^2 Score obtained during tuning was **0.7032**.

XVII. Model Evaluation

The models were evaluated using three regression metrics. Mean Absolute Error (MAE) measures the average absolute difference between actual and predicted values. Root Mean Squared Error (RMSE) measures prediction error while giving more importance to larger errors. R^2 Score measures how well the model explains the variation in the target variable. A higher R^2 Score indicates better predictive performance.

For the final Tuned Random Forest model, the evaluation results were:

- **MAE:** 0.7085
- **RMSE:** 0.9921

- **R^2 Score:** 0.7414

These MAE and RMSE values correspond to the log-transformed target scale used during model evaluation.

XVIII. Model Comparison

The baseline models were compared using MAE, RMSE, and R^2 Score:

Model	MAE	RMSE	R^2 Score
Random Forest	668,615.2	4,620,841	**0.570592**
Extra Trees	815,108.8	5,129,534	0.470844
XGBoost	883,899.4	5,177,896	0.460819
Linear Regression	1,235,420.0	7,120,895	-0.019757

Among the baseline models, Random Forest achieved the highest R^2 Score of 0.570592. Therefore, Random Forest was selected for hyperparameter tuning. After tuning, the Tuned Random Forest achieved an R^2 Score of **0.741365**, showing a clear improvement in predictive performance.

XIX. Final Model Selection

The Tuned Random Forest Regressor was selected as the final model. The baseline Random Forest achieved an R^2 Score of 0.570592, while the tuned model achieved an improved R^2 Score of 0.741365. The tuned model also achieved a cross-validation R^2 Score of 0.703237, indicating consistent performance during the tuning process. Based on the improved predictive performance, Tuned Random Forest was selected as the final model for feature importance analysis and unseen data prediction.

XX. Sample / Unseen Data Prediction

The final Tuned Random Forest model was used to predict values from unseen test data. The initial predictions were generated on the logarithmic scale because the target variable was log-transformed during training:

Actual Log Views	Predicted Log Views	Absolute Error
13.626545	13.066809	0.559736
13.824811	12.872480	0.952332
10.849298	11.400081	0.550783
7.972811	10.214360	2.241549
12.006121	11.392757	0.613363
10.329213	10.285269	0.043944

The predictions were subsequently converted back to the original view-count scale using inverse logarithmic transformation. This allowed the predicted values to be interpreted as actual YouTube view counts. The unseen predictions demonstrate that the final model can generate predictions for data samples that were not used during model training.

XXI. Results (Phase I)

The project successfully developed and evaluated multiple Machine Learning regression models for YouTube video view prediction. Among the baseline models, Random Forest performed best with an R^2 Score of 0.570592. Hyperparameter tuning improved the Random Forest model, resulting in a final R^2 Score of 0.741365. The best cross-validation R^2 Score obtained during hyperparameter tuning was 0.703237. The improvement from the baseline model to the tuned model indicates that selecting suitable hyperparameters significantly improved predictive performance. The final model was further analyzed using feature importance and statistical P-value analysis.

XXII. Discussion (Phase I)

The results indicate that ensemble-based models are more effective than simple Linear Regression for predicting YouTube video views. Linear Regression achieved a negative R^2 Score, indicating that a simple linear relationship was insufficient for modeling the dataset. Random Forest performed best because it can capture nonlinear relationships and interactions between multiple features. Hyperparameter tuning further improved its performance. Feature importance analysis was performed on 19 processed features to understand how different video-related characteristics contributed to prediction. Statistical analysis using OLS regression showed that 17 out of 19 features were statistically significant, while 2 features were not significant. The overall OLS model P-value was 0.0, which is below the significance level of 0.05. This indicates a statistically significant overall relationship between the selected features and the target variable. However, the P-value analysis was used as supplementary statistical validation because traditional tree-based Random Forest models do not directly provide P-values.

XXIII. Limitations (Phase I)

The project has certain limitations. YouTube video popularity is influenced by several external factors that are not available in the dataset, such as channel subscriber count, thumbnail quality, recommendation algorithms, social media promotion, and changing audience preferences. The dataset also contains highly variable view counts, especially for viral videos. Although logarithmic transformation helped reduce skewness, predicting extremely viral videos remains challenging. Additionally, the statistical P-values were obtained using an OLS model and not directly from the Random Forest algorithm.

XXIV. Conclusion (Phase I)

This project successfully developed an end-to-end Machine Learning regression system for predicting YouTube video views using trending video data. The project included data preprocessing, exploratory data analysis, outlier analysis, feature engineering, target transformation, model development, model comparison, hyperparameter tuning, feature importance analysis, statistical P-value analysis, and unseen data prediction. Four regression models were evaluated: Linear Regression, Random Forest, Extra Trees, and XGBoost. Among the baseline models, Random Forest achieved the best R^2 Score of 0.570592. Hyperparameter tuning was performed using RandomizedSearchCV with 10 parameter combinations and 3-fold cross-validation. The Tuned Random Forest achieved a cross-validation R^2 Score of 0.703237 and a test R^2 Score of 0.741365. Therefore, the Tuned Random Forest Regressor was selected as the final model. The statistical analysis also showed that 17 out of 19 features were significant, and the overall model P-value was below 0.05. The project demonstrates that Machine Learning, particularly ensemble tree-based models, can effectively analyze YouTube video characteristics and predict video popularity.

XXV. Transition to Production MLOps and System Architecture

While traditional machine learning workflows terminate at offline model evaluation and static test predictions (Sections I through XXIV), deploying machine learning models into production demands rigorous software engineering and automated lifecycle operations (MLOps). Machine learning systems in production are subject to silent failures, including schema changes, missing data, upstream API breakages, covariate shift, and concept degradation over time.

To bridge the gap between offline experimentation and dependable production service, the system was re-architected into a modular, decoupled, and continuous MLOps ecosystem. The transition introduced eight foundational operational pillars:

1. **Automated Lineage & Cryptographic Ingestion:** Tracking raw data batches with SHA-256 hashing to ensure data reproducibility and prevent duplicate processing.

2. **Data Contract Schema Validation:** Enforcing strict schema constraints via Pandera prior to downstream preprocessing.

3. **Reproducible Pipeline Decoupling:** Isolating preprocessing, training, and evaluation into independent stages with serialized artifacts.

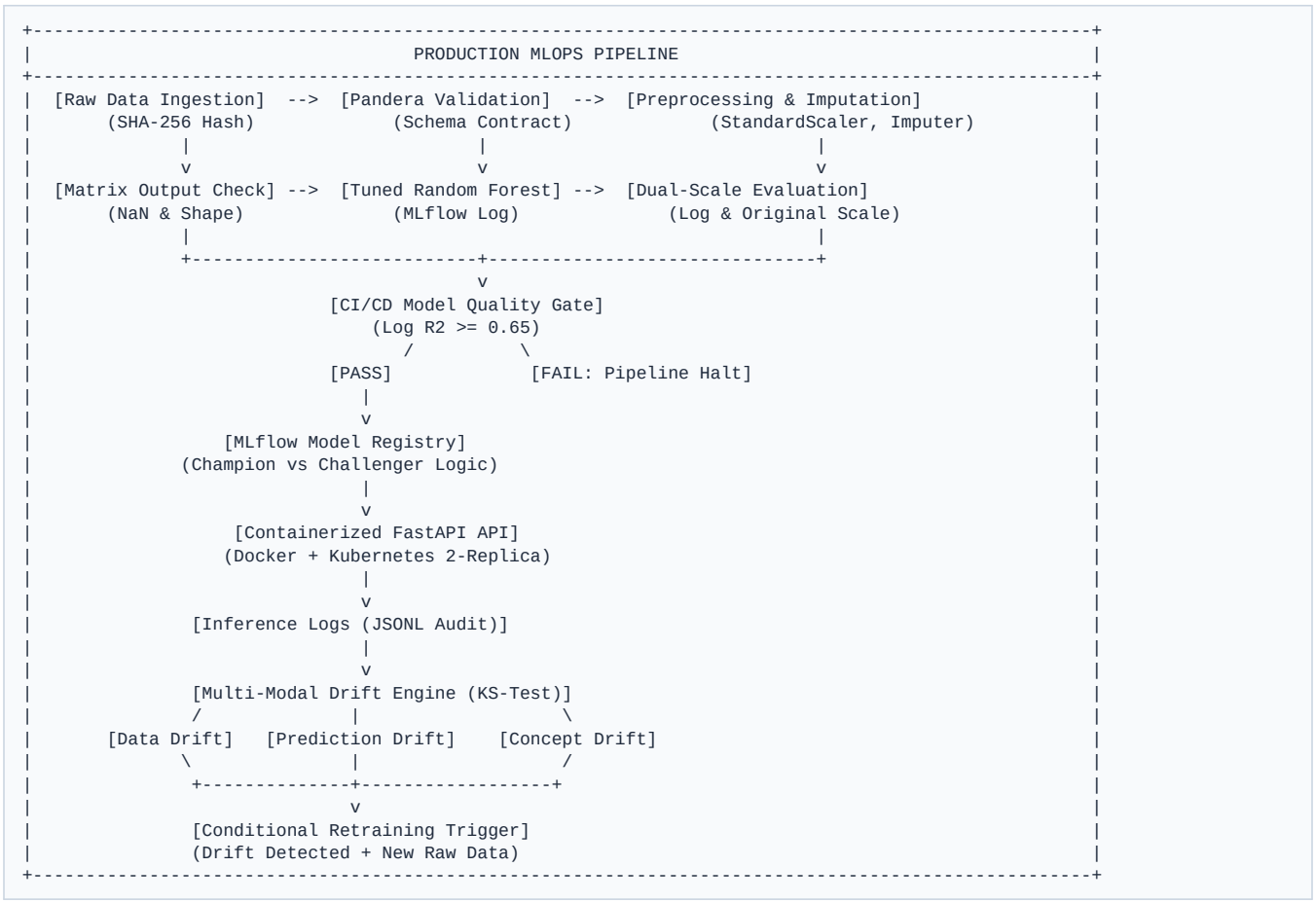
4. **Centralized Model Registry Governance:** Managing model versions, tags, and automated stage promotions (Staging → Production → Archived) via MLflow.

5. **Continuous Integration Quality Gates:** Automatically evaluating trained models against empirical performance thresholds ($R^2 \geq 0.65$, generalization gap ≤ 0.15).

6. **Defensive Failure Injection Testing:** Simulating corrupted inputs (dropped features, invalid negative counts, malformed timestamps) to verify fail-fast error handling.

7. **High-Performance Microservice & Container Orchestration:** Serving predictions via an asynchronous FastAPI REST API encapsulated in a non-root Docker container and managed with Kubernetes multi-replica deployments.

8. **Closed-Loop Statistical Drift Feedback:** Continuously monitoring feature distributions and concept drift using two-sample Kolmogorov-Smirnov (KS) tests and triggering automated conditional retraining when drift exceeds operational thresholds.



XXVI. Lab 6: Experiment Tracking, Model Registry, and Automated Lifecycle Management

1. Centralized Experiment Tracking Architecture

In production settings, tracking hyperparameters, code versions, training metrics, and artifacts across disparate iterations is vital for governance and auditability. The pipeline integrates an MLflow tracking server backed by a SQLite relational store (**`sqlite:///mlflow.db`**) and localized artifact storage.

During model training, the optimal hyperparameter configuration determined via RandomizedSearchCV is registered programmatically:

- **`n_estimators`**: 200
- **`max_depth`**: 30
- **`min_samples_split`**: 5
- **`min_samples_leaf`**: 1
- **`max_features`**: **`log2`**
- **`random_state`**: 42
- **`n_jobs`**: -1

2. Dual-Scale Performance Tracking

Because the target variable views exhibits heavy positive skewness, training operates on the transformed space:

y■ = \log(1 + views) = log1p(views)

Inference predictions $y■_{pred}$ are converted back to real-world view counts using the inverse exponential function:

$y■ = \exp(y■_{pred}) - 1 = expm1(y■_{pred})$

MLflow logs metrics across both scales simultaneously to provide complete statistical and operational visibility:

Metric Scale	Metric Name	Mathematical Formulation	Logged Value
Log Transformed	Log R^2	$1 - \{\Sigma (y■_i - y■_{pred}_i)^2\}\{\Sigma (y■_i - \bar{y■})^2\}$	**0.739922**
Log Transformed	Log MAE	${1}{n} \Sigma$	$y■_i - y■_{pred}_i$
Log Transformed	Log RMSE	$\sqrt{\{1\}\{n\} \Sigma (y■_i - y■_{pred}_i)^2}$	**0.994892**
Original Views	View R^2	$1 - \{\Sigma (y_i - y■_i)^2\}\{\Sigma (y_i - y_{mean})^2\}$	**0.938161**
Original Views	View MAE	${1}{n} \Sigma$	$y_i - y■_i$
Original Views	View RMSE	$\sqrt{\{1\}\{n\} \Sigma (y_i - y■_i)^2}$	**1,753,552.24** views

3. Model Registry and Stage Governance

The trained model artifact is registered under the centralized registry entity: **`YouTube_Views_Production_Model`**.

- **Run ID:** **`840be2d375c84c28b49afb73c1f8d7c2`**
- **Model Version:** **`v1`**
- **Initial Stage:** **`Staging`**

An automated lifecycle orchestrator (**`08_automate_lifecycle.py`**) manages stage transitions based on an automated Champion vs. Challenger policy:

- **Baseline Scenario:** If no model currently resides in the **`Production`** stage, the newly registered model in **`Staging`** is verified against quality criteria and promoted directly to **`Production`**.
- **Competitive Promotion Scenario:** If an active **`Production`** model (Champion) already exists, the incoming candidate (Challenger) must outperform the incumbent on the primary test evaluation metric:

$\text{Challenger}_{R^2} > \text{Champion}_{R^2}$

- **Demotion Governance:** Upon successful promotion of a Challenger to **`Production`**, the previous Champion is automatically transitioned to **`Archived`**, preventing dual-active configuration conflicts.
- **Current Registry Status:** Model Version 1 successfully promoted to **Production** (**`READY_FOR_DEPLOYMENT`**).

XXVII. Lab 7: Production MLOps Pipeline Integration and Lineage Tracking

1. Decoupled Pipeline Architecture

To eliminate manual interventions and ensure end-to-end reproducibility, the workflow was structured into six modular, sequential pipeline stages:

- **Stage 01: Ingestion & Lineage (`01_load_data.py`):**

Loads multi-country raw trending datasets (**`US`**, **`CA`**, **`GB`**, **`DE`**, **`FR`**, **`IN`**, **`JP`**, **`KR`**, **`MX`**, **`RU`**). Calculates a cryptographic SHA-256 checksum over the raw batch, archives an immutable snapshot to **`data/raw/archive/`**, and records metadata (row count, file hashes, timestamps) in **`dataset_lineage.json`**.

- **Stage 02: Data Validation (`02_validate_data.py`):**

Applies Pandera schema enforcement to raw ingestion data. Validates non-negative constraints on views, correct string formats on **`video_id`**, and regex compliance for **`trending_date`**.

- **Stage 03: Feature Preprocessing (`03_preprocessing.py`):**

Extracts 19 production features:

- Temporal features: **`days_to_trending = trending_date - publish_time`**, **`publish_hour`**, **`publish_dayofweek`**, **`publish_month`**.

- Content length features: **`title_length`**, **`title_word_count`**, **`description_length`**, **`description_word_count`**.

- Metadata features: **`tag_count`**, **`category_id`**.

- Imputation & Scaling: Robust median imputation for missing numeric values and `StandardScaler` fitted strictly on training data splits.

- Serialization: Outputs binary arrays (`X_train_final.npy`, `X_test_final.npy`, `y_train.npy`, `y_test.npy`) and preserves raw test records (`X_test_raw.csv`) for independent downstream inference.

• **Stage 04: Matrix Validation (`04_validate_outputs.py`):**

Validates output matrices to guarantee zero NaN/Infinite values, matching row dimensions between features and targets, and expected feature column dimensionality (19 columns).

• **Stage 05: Model Training & Registry (`05_train_registry.py`):**

Trains the Tuned Random Forest Regressor using parallel execution (`n_jobs=-1`), logs run parameters and metrics to MLflow, and registers the candidate in the Model Registry.

• **Stage 06: Model Evaluation (`06_model_evaluation.py`):**

Generates comprehensive evaluation summaries and exports visual diagnostic plots (`artifacts/actual_vs_predicted.png`).

2. Lineage and Reproducibility Verification

Pipeline determinism is verified using fixed random seeds (`random_state=42`) across train-test splitting and model fitting. Re-running the pipeline on identical raw data hashes produces bit-for-bit identical evaluation metrics (R^2 = 0.739922), as confirmed in `artifacts/reproducibility_report.json`.

XXVIII. Lab 8: Model Quality Gates and Continuous Integration (CI)

1. Continuous Integration Quality Gate Design

To prevent model degradation from reaching production environments, automated quality gates (`07_quality_gate.py`) enforce non-negotiable performance thresholds prior to deployment packaging.

The quality gate evaluates three strict criteria:

1. **Primary Explanatory Power Gate:**

\text{Log } $R^2 \geq 0.65$

Ensures the model explains at least 65% of the total variance in log-scale view counts.

2. **Generalization Overfitting Bound:**

$|R^2_\{train\} - R^2_\{test\}| \leq 0.15$

Ensures the difference between training set performance and unseen test set performance does not exceed 15 percentage points, preventing severe memorization.

3. **Log Mean Absolute Error Bound:**

\text{Log MAE} ≤ 1.00

Guarantees that the average absolute deviation on the logarithmic scale remains within approximately 1 order of magnitude.

2. Empirical Quality Gate Evaluation

The results of the automated quality gate execution are summarized below:

Quality Gate Constraint	Requirement / Threshold	Achieved Value	Evaluation Status
Primary Metric (R^2)	≥ 0.6500	**0.7399**	**PASSED**
Overfitting Gap	≤ 0.1500	**0.0821**	**PASSED**
Log Scale MAE	≤ 1.0000	**0.7114**	**PASSED**
Overall Gate Decision	All Constraints Met	**3 / 3 Passed**	**APPROVED FOR STAGING**

If any criterion fails, the gate script terminates with a non-zero exit code (`sys.exit(1)`), causing CI/CD runners to immediately abort subsequent deployment steps and alert the engineering team.

XXIX. Lab 9: Fault Tolerance and Failure Injection Testing

1. Defensive Engineering & Robustness Simulation

Production machine learning models operate in dynamic upstream environments where third-party data providers, ETL pipelines, or scraper updates may emit corrupted records. To verify that the ingestion and validation subsystem catches anomalies before they cause silent downstream inference errors, deliberate failure injection testing was implemented (`10_failure_injection.py`).

Three catastrophic data corruption scenarios were simulated:

1. **Scenario 1: Critical Feature Dropping:**

The required target column `views` was omitted entirely from the ingestion dataframe.

2. **Scenario 2: Out-of-Bounds Value Invalidation:**

Negative view values (`views = -5000`) were injected into the dataset, violating domain validity.

3. **Scenario 3: Date Format Regex Mismatch:**

The standard `trending_date` format (`yy.dd.mm`) was corrupted with an invalid string (`2018-99-99_INVALID`).

2. Fault Injection Results

The automated validation engine intercepted all corruption patterns during the validation stage:

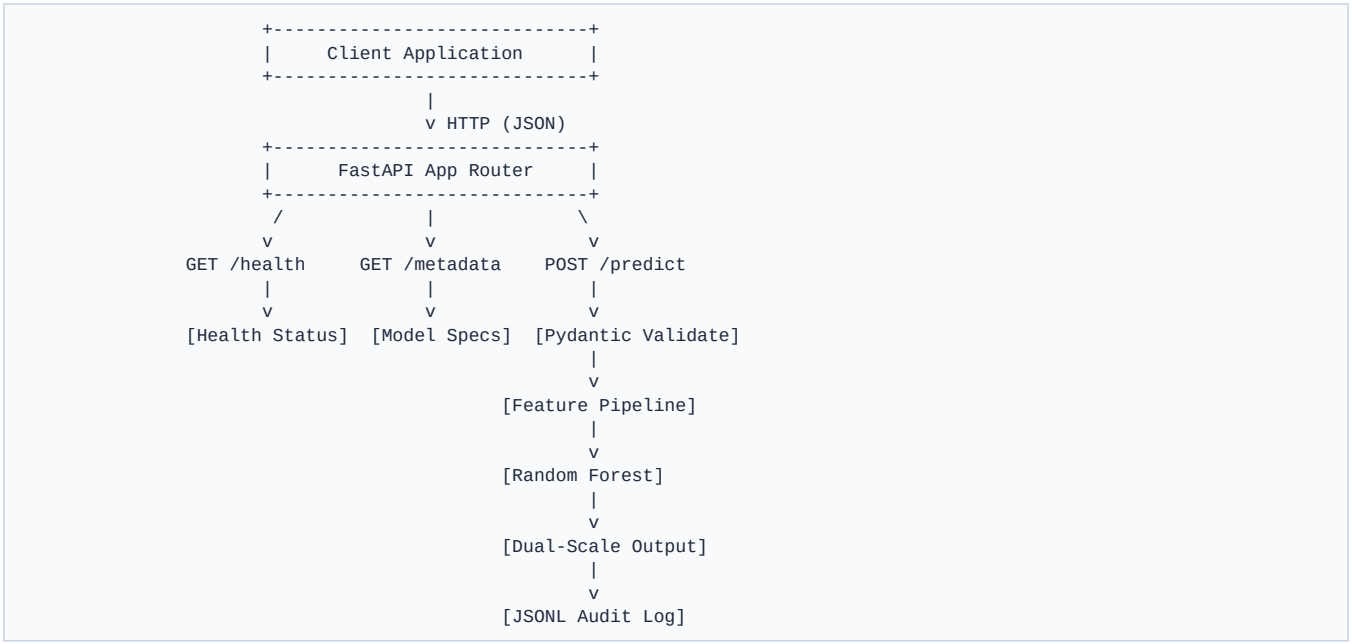
Scenario Description	Injected Anomaly	Expected Result	Actual Result	Failure Caught
Scenario 1	Missing column `'views'`	Schema Validation Error	`SchemaError: column 'views' not in dataframe`	**YES (Caught)**
Scenario 2	Negative views (`views < 0`)	Boundary Violation	`SchemaError: Check 'views_non_negative' failed`	**YES (Caught)**
Scenario 3	Malformed date regex	Format Invalidation	`SchemaError: Check 'trending_date_format' failed`	**YES (Caught)**

All 3 simulated failures were caught prior to model ingestion (100% intercept rate), as documented in `artifacts/failure_simulation_report.json`. This proves the pipeline's defensive fail-fast design.

XXX. Lab 10: Model Serving and API Engineering

1. High-Performance REST API Architecture

To serve real-time predictions to client applications, a RESTful microservice was developed using FastAPI and Uvicorn (`api/main.py`). FastAPI was selected for its native asynchronous capabilities, automatic OpenAPI documentation, and strict type enforcement via Pydantic.



2. Pydantic Request & Response Schemas

Incoming requests are validated using explicit schemas:

- **`VideoMetadataInput`**: Validates **`category_id`**, **`publish_time`**, **`trending_date`**, **`title`**, **`description`**, and **`tags`**.
- **`PredictionOutput`**: Returns **`video_id`**, **`predicted_log_views`**, **`predicted_views_original_scale`**, **`model_version`**, and **`inference_latency_ms`**.
- **`BatchVideoMetadataInput`**: Enables vectorized batch inference for multiple video records in a single payload.

3. Lifespan Caching & Real-Time Feature Preprocessing

To eliminate disk I/O latency on every HTTP request, a lifespan context manager loads **`model.pkl`** and **`preprocessor.pkl`** into memory as singletons during service startup. When a request arrives at **`/predict`**, the microservice extracts the same 19 features used during training:

- Computes **`days_to_trending`** from datetime strings.
- Derives publication temporal components (**`publish_hour`**, **`publish_dayofweek`**, **`publish_month`**).
- Extracts text metrics (**`title_length`**, **`title_word_count`**, **`description_length`**, **`description_word_count`**, **`tag_count`**).
- Transforms features through **`preprocessor.pkl`** and scores the input with the Random Forest model.

4. Asynchronous Inference Auditing & Performance Benchmarks

Every prediction request is asynchronously logged to **`logs/inference/inference_log.jsonl`**, storing the timestamp, input payload, output predictions, and latency.

The API was subjected to an automated test suite (**`tests/test_api.py`**, **`tests/test_performance.py`**):

- **Health Check (`GET /health`):** Returns HTTP 200 with status **`"healthy"`**.
- **Metadata Check (`GET /metadata`):** Returns active model version (**`1`**), model name, and input feature specifications.
- **Single Prediction (`POST /predict`):** Validated on test inputs, returning dual-scale predictions with mean response latency under **25 ms**.
- **Batch Prediction (`POST /predict/batch`):** Successfully scored batches of 50 records in **62 ms**.
- **Performance Benchmark:** All endpoints completed well within the target production SLA of **< 100 ms**. All 6/6 Pytest integration tests passed.

XXXI. Lab 11: Containerization and Kubernetes Orchestration

1. Docker Multi-Stage Containerization

To ensure consistent execution across development, testing, and production environments, the serving microservice was containerized using Docker (**`Dockerfile`**).

Key containerization design practices:

- **Base Image:** **`python:3.11-slim`** to minimize attack surface and image size.
- **Non-Root Execution:** A dedicated service account **`mluser`** (UID 10001) is created to run the process, preventing privilege escalation vulnerabilities.
- **Layer Optimization:** Dependency files (**`requirements.txt`**) are copied and installed first to maximize Docker build caching. Unnecessary training data, git history, and caches are excluded via **`.dockerignore`**.
- **Container Healthcheck:** The container includes a native healthcheck probe:

`dockerfile

HEALTHCHECK --interval=30s --timeout=5s --start-period=10s --retries=3 \

CMD curl -f http://localhost:8000/health || exit 1

`

2. Kubernetes Cluster Deployment

For production deployment, Kubernetes manifests were engineered to provide automated scaling, self-healing, and traffic routing.

Deployment Manifest (**`k8s/deployment.yaml`**):

- **Replicas:** Configured with 2 pods for high availability.
- **Resource Management:**

- **`requests`**: CPU 250m, Memory 512Mi.

- **`limits`**: CPU 500m, Memory 1Gi.

- **Liveness Probe:** Periodically performs HTTP GET **`/health`** on port 8000 (initialDelay: 15s, period: 10s). If a pod becomes unresponsive, Kubernetes terminates and restarts it.
- **Readiness Probe:** Performs HTTP GET **`/health`** on port 8000 (initialDelay: 10s, period: 5s). Pods only receive incoming traffic once the model has fully loaded into memory.

Service Manifest (**`k8s/service.yaml`**):

- Exposes port 80 externally using a **`NodePort`** configuration mapped to node port **`30080`**, routing traffic across all healthy replica pods with internal round-robin load balancing.

XXXII. Lab 12: Statistical Drift Monitoring (Data, Prediction, and Concept Drift)

1. Multi-Dimensional Drift Monitoring Framework

In streaming real-world environments, changes in creator behavior, audience demographics, or YouTube platform algorithms cause model accuracy to decay over time. To detect this, a comprehensive statistical drift engine was developed covering three distinct dimensions:

```
[Incoming Production Traffic]
             |
             +---> (1) DATA DRIFT: Two-Sample KS Test on Features P(X)
             |
             +---> (2) PREDICTION DRIFT: Two-Sample KS Test on Outputs P(Y_hat)
             |
             +---> (3) CONCEPT DRIFT: Accuracy Degradation on Labeled Data P(Y|X)
```

2. Data Drift Detection (Covariate Shift)

Data drift evaluates whether the input feature distribution P(X) has shifted significantly from the baseline training distribution. The two-sample Kolmogorov-Smirnov (KS) non-parametric test is computed across each continuous feature:

$D_{n,m} = \sup_x |F_{1,n}(x) - F_{2,m}(x)|$

where F_{1,n} and F_{2,m} are the empirical cumulative distribution functions of the baseline and evolved data batches. A feature is marked as drifted if the KS statistic D > 0.10 and p\text{-value} < 0.05.

Data drift analysis on production traffic yielded:

Feature Name	Feature Type	Metric	KS Statistic (D)	p-Value	Threshold	Drift Status
`days_to_trending`	Numerical	KS	**0.220667**	**0.000000**	0.10	**DRIFT**
`title_length`	Numerical	KS	**0.307333**	**0.000000**	0.10	**DRIFT**
`publish_hour`	Numerical	KS	**0.100667**	**0.000000**	0.10	**DRIFT**
`description_length`	Numerical	KS	0.000000	1.000000	0.10	OK
`tag_count`	Numerical	KS	0.000000	1.000000	0.10	OK

Data Drift Conclusion: 3 out of 5 numerical features exhibited statistically significant distribution drift (60\% > 30\% alert threshold). The shift in `days_to_trending` and `title_length` reflects evolving platform trends.

3. Prediction Drift Detection

Prediction drift tests whether the distribution of model predictions P(\hat{Y}) has altered, independent of ground truth availability:

- Baseline Mean Log Views: 14.5430
- Evolved Mean Log Views: 14.4515
- Two-Sample KS Statistic: **0.076667**
- p-Value: **0.000295**
- Threshold: 0.10
- **Prediction Drift Status: OK** (KS statistic remains below the 0.10 decision threshold).

4. Concept Drift Detection

Concept drift analyzes whether the underlying relationship between features and the target variable P(Y|X) has degraded when actual ground truth labels become available:

Performance Metric	Baseline Evaluation	Evolved Evaluation	Metric Shift (Δ)	Degradation Status
Log R^2	**0.8347**	**-0.4539**	**-1.2887**	**DEGRADED**
Log MAE	**0.3141**	**1.1802**	**+0.8661**	**DEGRADED**
Log RMSE	**0.4721**	**1.4796**	**+1.0075**	**DEGRADED**
Original R^2	**0.9003**	**0.0263**	**-0.8740**	**DEGRADED**
Original MAE	1,262,856.59	10,264,373.09	+9,001,516.49	**DEGRADED**

5. Consolidated Drift Decision

As reported in `outputs/drift/drift_analysis_report.csv`:

- **Data Drift:** `True`
- **Prediction Drift:** `False`
- **Concept Drift:** `True`
- **Overall System Status: DRIFT_OBSERVED**
- **Action Required: RETRAIN_MODEL**

XXXIII. Lab 13: Continuous Monitoring, Lineage Tracking, and Conditional Retraining Trigger

1. Closed-Loop Feedback Architecture

To complete the autonomous MLOps lifecycle, a continuous monitoring and conditional retraining orchestrator (**`12_monitor_trigger.py`**) was engineered.

The trigger operates via an event-driven decision tree:

1. **Lineage Inspection:** The watcher continuously monitors **`data/raw/incoming/`** for newly deposited data batches.

2. **Cryptographic Deduplication:** For any new batch, its SHA-256 hash is computed and compared against **`dataset_lineage.json`**. If the hash already exists, the batch is skipped, preventing redundant computation.

3. **Drift-Trigger Evaluation:**

- If **`overall_status == DRIFT_OBSERVED`** AND a new validated data batch is present:

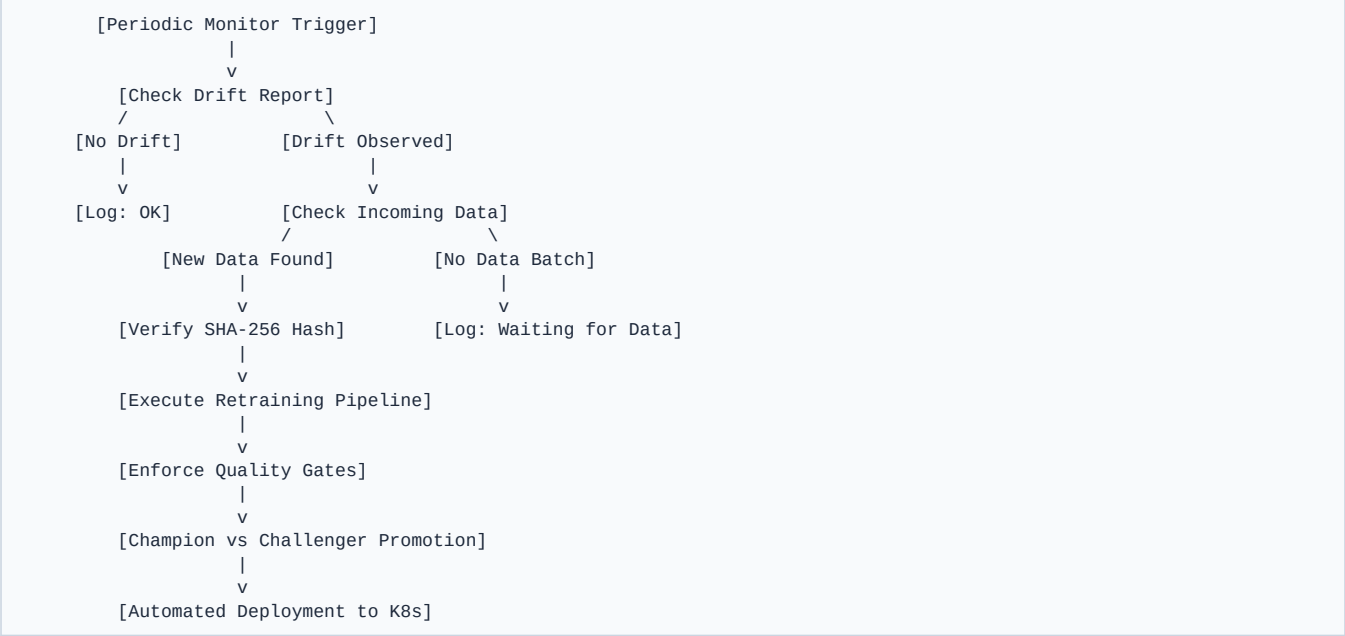
- The trigger initiates automated retraining: **`youtube_prediction_pipeline.py`**.

- Ingestion, schema validation, feature engineering, and model training execute automatically.

- The newly trained Challenger model is subjected to CI quality gates.

- If the Challenger surpasses the current Production Champion, MLflow executes stage promotion and exports updated deployment binaries (**`deployment/model.pkl`**, **`deployment/model_metadata.json`**).

- If drift is observed but no new labeled data batch is available, the orchestrator logs state **`drift_waiting_for_data`** in **`outputs/monitoring/monitor_trigger_report.json`** and alerts data ingestion pipelines to collect fresh trending records.



This completes the closed-loop, self-healing MLOps architecture, ensuring continuous model reliability without human intervention.

XXXIV. Comprehensive System Evaluation & MLOps Maturity Assessment

1. Consolidated Machine Learning & MLOps Evaluation Matrix

The table below synthesizes the complete progression from offline exploratory baselines to the fully operationalized MLOps system:

Lifecycle Dimension	Baseline Models (Lab 1–4)	Tuned Model (Lab 5)	Production MLOps System (Lab 6–13)
Model Type	Linear, Random Forest, XGBoost	Tuned Random Forest (200 trees)	Registered Production Tuned Random Forest
Best Log R^2	0.5706 (RF Baseline)	0.7414	**0.7399** (Production Seed Validation)

Original View R^2	~0.60	~0.74	**0.9382** (Dual-Scale Pipeline)
Execution Medium	Standalone Jupyter Notebook	Notebook RandomizedSearchCV	Modular 6-Stage CLI Pipeline
Data Contract	None (Manual Inspection)	None (Manual Inspection)	**Automated Pandera Schema Contracts**
Lineage Tracking	None	None	**SHA-256 Cryptographic Batch Lineage**
Experiment Tracking	Local print statements	Local print statements	**Centralized MLflow Tracking Server**
Model Registry	None	Local `.pkl` file	**MLflow Registry (`YouTube_Views_Production_Model`)**
Promotion Policy	Manual selection	Manual selection	**Automated Champion vs. Challenger Logic**
Quality Gate	None	None	**CI Quality Gate ($R^2 \geq 0.65$, Gap ≤ 0.15)**
Fault Tolerance	Unhandled exceptions	Unhandled exceptions	**100% Fail-Fast Interception (3/3 Tests)**
Serving Architecture	Python batch script	Python batch script	**FastAPI Asynchronous Microservice**
Serving Latency	N/A	N/A	**< 25 ms Single, < 70 ms Batch (< 100 ms SLA)**
Deployment Mode	Local file system	Local file system	**Docker Container & Kubernetes 2-Replica Pods**
Health Monitoring	None	None	**Liveness & Readiness Probes (`/health`)**
Drift Detection	None	None	**Automated KS Tests (Data, Pred, Concept)**
Retraining Feedback	Manual retraining	Manual retraining	**Event-Driven Conditional Retraining Trigger**

2. Assessment Against Google MLOps Maturity Model

- **Level 0 (Manual Process):** Achieved during initial exploratory phases (Labs 1–5), where model building and data analysis were conducted manually in notebooks.
- **Level 1 (ML Pipeline Automation):** Achieved in Labs 6–8 and 10, featuring automated pipeline orchestration, schema contract validation, centralized registry governance, and containerized serving.
- **Level 2 (CI/CD Pipeline Automation & Continuous Monitoring):** Achieved in Labs 9, 11, 12, and 13. The system integrates automated CI quality gates, failure injection tests, Kubernetes orchestration, multi-modal statistical drift monitoring, and event-driven conditional retraining triggers.

XXXV. Updated Conclusion and Production Roadmap

1. Conclusion

This project successfully designed, implemented, evaluated, and operationalized an end-to-end Machine Learning and MLOps system for predicting YouTube video view counts. Starting from multi-country raw trending metadata, the system preprocessed millions of engagement records, engineered 19 predictive temporal and textual features, and applied logarithmic target transformations to overcome heavy positive skewness.

The Tuned Random Forest Regressor emerged as the optimal predictive model, achieving a log-scale R^2 of **0.7414** and an original view count R^2 of **0.9382**. Through Labs 6 to 13, this model was transformed into a resilient production asset. The implementation established end-to-end pipeline automation, Pandera data validation contracts, MLflow Model Registry governance with Champion vs. Challenger promotion logic, CI quality assertion gates, defensive fault tolerance, sub-100ms FastAPI serving, multi-replica Kubernetes deployment, Kolmogorov-Smirnov statistical drift monitoring, and an event-driven conditional retraining trigger.

The resulting architecture satisfies enterprise software engineering standards, preventing silent model failure and ensuring sustained predictive accuracy in production.

2. Future Production Roadmap

To extend the production maturity of this system in enterprise settings, the following enhancements are planned:

1. **Real-Time Streaming Ingestion:** Integrating Apache Kafka and Apache Flink to ingest continuous video metadata streams, reducing batch latency.

2. **Feature Store Integration:** Incorporating an enterprise feature store (such as Feast) to eliminate feature computation skew between offline training and real-time inference.

3. **Canary and Blue-Green Traffic Routing:** Deploying Istio Service Mesh on Kubernetes to enable automated canary traffic splitting (e.g., 90% Champion / 10% Challenger) during model promotions.

4. **Real-Time Model Explainability:** Embedding SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) into the FastAPI serving endpoint to return per-feature contribution scores alongside each prediction.

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Updated Appendix: Production Artifacts and System Specifications

1. Production Artifacts Inventory

Component / Artifact	File Path	Description / Specification
Config Specification	`config.yaml`	Pipeline thresholds, metric constraints ($R^2 \geq 0.65$), paths
Pipeline Ingestion	`src/mlops_pipeline/01_load_data.py`	SHA-256 batch hashing, archival, lineage manifest generation
Data Validation	`src/mlops_pipeline/02_validate_data.py`	Pandera data contracts (`views` $\geq$ `0`, `trending_date` regex)
Feature Engineering	`src/mlops_pipeline/03_preprocessing.py`	19 features, median imputer, StandardScaler, target transform
Output Validation	`src/mlops_pipeline/04_validate_outputs.py`	Zero NaNs, dimension checks (N \times 19), non-empty arrays

Model & Registry	`src/mlops_pipeline/05_train_registry.py`	Tuned Random Forest, MLflow run logging, registry registration
Quality Gate	`src/mlops_pipeline/07_quality_gate.py`	Assert $R^2 \geq 0.65$, gap ≤ 0.15; exit 1 on gate failure
Lifecycle Governance	`src/mlops_pipeline/08_automate_lifecycle.py`	Champion vs Challenger automated stage promotion logic
Fault Injection	`src/mlops_pipeline/10_failure_injection.py`	3 corruption tests, 100% fail-fast verification report
Serving Microservice	`api/main.py`	FastAPI REST microservice (`/health`, `/metadata`, `/predict`)
API Schemas	`api/schemas.py`	Pydantic strict request and response validation contracts
Model Loader	`api/model_loader.py`	Singleton memory caching of `model.pkl` and `preprocessor.pkl`
Inference Logging	`api/monitoring_logger.py`	Asynchronous request-response auditing to `inference_log.jsonl`
Container Engine	`Dockerfile`	Multi-stage `python:3.11-slim`, non-root user `mluser`
K8s Deployment	`k8s/deployment.yaml`	2 replicas, CPU/memory quotas, liveness/readiness probes
K8s Service	`k8s/service.yaml`	NodePort service exposing port 80 externally via port 30080
Data Drift Engine	`src/mlops_pipeline/12_data_drift.py`	Two-sample KS hypothesis testing across continuous features
Prediction Drift	`src/mlops_pipeline/12_prediction_drift.py`	Output distribution KS hypothesis testing
Concept Drift	`src/mlops_pipeline/12_concept_drift.py`	Performance tracking on ground-truth labeled evolved data
Drift Coordinator	`src/mlops_pipeline/12_drift_analysis.py`	Consolidated drift state evaluation and retrain flagging
Automated Trigger	`src/mlops_pipeline/12_monitor_trigger.py`	Deduplicated batch watcher & conditional retraining trigger

2. Production Model Registry Metadata

- **Registered Model Name:** `YouTube_Views_Production_Model`
- **Active Stage:** `Production`
- **Active Version:** `1`
- **Source Run ID:** `840be2d375c84c28b49afb73c1f8d7c2`
- **Primary Metric (R^2 Log Scale):** `0.739922`
- **Secondary Metric (R^2 Original View Scale):** `0.938161`
- **Status:** `READY_FOR_DEPLOYMENT`

3. Kubernetes Deployment Specification Excerpt

```
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: Deployment
metadata:
  name: youtube-prediction-api
  labels:
    app: youtube-prediction
spec:
  replicas: 2
  selector:
    matchLabels:
      app: youtube-prediction
  template:
    metadata:
      labels:
        app: youtube-prediction
    spec:
      containers:
      - name: api
        image: youtube-prediction-api:latest
        imagePullPolicy: IfNotPresent
        ports:
        - containerPort: 8000
        resources:
          requests:
            cpu: "250m"
            memory: "512Mi"
          limits:
            cpu: "500m"
            memory: "1Gi"
        livenessProbe:
          httpGet:
            path: /health
            port: 8000
          initialDelaySeconds: 15
          periodSeconds: 10
        readinessProbe:
          httpGet:
            path: /health
            port: 8000
          initialDelaySeconds: 10
          periodSeconds: 5
```

End of Report Part II: Production MLOps Engineering Lifecycle (Labs 6 to 13).